

3/5/2016 – PRAASA Late Night Discussion “Steps, Traditions, Concepts – Does Our Program Have Meaning to the Newcomer?”

I tried to capture as much of your content as I possibly could. Please forgive me if I didn't quite quote you accurately. It is my intention that these notes, at best, captured the language of your hearts.

11:00 PM Mary N. opened the discussion with the Serenity Prayer

Michael – Area 9, Mid S. CA, District 14 – Grateful to be here. Language of the heart connects us with people. Having a sponsor, doing the steps, reading the book are all part of my sobriety. I'm happy to be a part of AA. The tools help you connect with the people through the language of the heart. It brings us to another level to connect with the newcomer.

Elizabeth – DCM Dist 10, Area 58 – Yes/No. I look at myself, am I reaching out instead of talking to friends? If I see a newcomer, do I walk over and shake hands? When I was new I felt I was on the outside. A year later I realized I was keeping myself back. Today I realize how I kept myself back. I'm emotional and shared tears. I share from the heart. The newcomer is the most important person in the room. Sometimes while reading during a meeting we have to see if the newcomer is connecting.

Ed – The wise man was walking down the road ^{and} discovered the truth. The devil said “can I organize them for you?”. 1935 – Simple ideas. 1955 – More complicated ideas. Later the concepts, even more of a mystery to me. They get more complicated as they go on. We were all newcomers once. Time and keep coming back keeps us going. The people who are committed are the ones you see in service. 1 in 10 stay. Half of those that stay go into service. Be empathetic to the newcomer. Guide and show them the way.

Elmer – I get to come to PRAASA and listen to what goes on here and at the district level. We discuss many things but there is no real urgency. We are still very relevant. AA will go on, we will still make coffee, we will still have meetings, drunk's will still get sober. Show them the 12 Steps Illustrated 1st step with the big bottle crushing the guy. Find out if they want to come back. Alcoholism has been around thousands of years. Our 80 years of moving forward are what is relevant. That one person will come and stay and make coffee and do the steps. Some of the people that come because of the court system stay around so what the court system seems to think we are relevant.

Georgia SD 3/11/88 – When I got here they thanked me for allowing them to 12th step me. They told me I had to pray. I had God problems at the time. I worked the steps backward. I don't know what tomorrow brings but I know what I have today. I can be available without being responsible. If I give out my number but don't lend assistance when someone calls, I'm not being responsible.

Jenny SD 2/6/87 – Nobody asked me to keep coming back. I was angry. I was sentenced to AA. I didn't have a choice. I thought you were losers. No one wanted to be around me. I would dare the secretary to not sign my card. I would throw it down on the table. I was looking for people to tell me not to come back. It wasn't the steps/trad/con. I kept coming back and I heard another alcoholic say she hated herself. The identification of that was how I felt. The steps came later. I need to hear the language of the heart.

Kevin – Personal belief. The history of the 12 steps/trads/con Bill wanted everything in 12's. Bob had 3. Earlier they had 6. Bob was getting close to dying so, in Cleveland, they had the first convention to show

Bob what he and Bill had started. Bob said it comes down to two things; love and service. We have to reach out to the newcomer. One alcoholic reaches out to another alcoholic. Back in the day no one cared about the steps or the big book. It was instead one alcoholic talking to another. Hardest part is showing up for your first meeting.

Carla – In Spanish groups in my area you are a newcomer until you have 5 years. If you'd showed me the steps/trad I wouldn't have come back. The Promises is what I wanted. We need to focus on the promises. Later you make the connection to the steps. Sometimes when you get sober you forget what it was like for you in the beginning. The program doesn't make sense to the newcomer right away.

Crystal – There is no time limit on newcomers. We give the newcomer the language of the heart. Grapevine articles give it meaning. We share our experiences. Sometimes you feel like you are missing out on something. I didn't want to be the one who didn't know.

Mary – We are currently running down to about 10 minutes left to our discussion.

Mike – There are different ways for different people. I share with them what I do. I go to the Big Book step 1 and then to the 12/12 step 1 and so on. Our home group is a big book study and we read the long version of the traditions. Steps help me, traditions help the group, concepts ensure the program is still around. Learning the concepts through experience rather than just reading.

Pete – Came to the program out of the penitentiary. Went to the Serenity House in Spokane. I didn't work and moved around a lot. Got in trouble again and came back around. I found that you never have to drink again, one day at a time if you don't want to. I didn't know that I could not drink. When I heard that I wondered what is the real deal in AA. I shared simply – "help me". It made me vulnerable and gave me release. 7 months later I still had thoughts and actions that were inappropriate. I went to the "Back to Basics" beginners class (4 hrs). I haven't drank since. The steps/trad are simple, we complicate them. The traditions protect us from ourselves. Since working the steps, I've taken people through the steps. Keep it simple. The steps/trad can be very relevant.

Melisa – Area 6 GSR San Mateo, CA – I'm sober 12 years and the concepts are obtuse to me. I think a lot of the group don't understand. The group is new to having a GSR. This is news to most people in our group. We have an idea of politics but not concepts. Wish it was easier to understand and more information was available.

Rico SD 5/15/12 Area 93, Central CA – It does help the newcomer coming in and staying. I don't think I quite understood it. There was a life I thought I didn't deserve. Quite often we aren't informed. I felt better about living life. I could think better. We practice these principles in all our affairs. If these didn't exist alcoholics would die, groups would fall apart. Without the concepts AA would cease to exist. The steps relieved me from hopelessness, the traditions show me how to get along with others.

Steve SD 5/28/79 – When I hit bottom everything was destroyed. Family was gone, purpose was gone. I felt I had nothing anymore, no real purpose. A staff member at the facility I was in said "your purpose is to find out where you belong and make it stronger". It gave me hope. AA is what I belonged to. Chap 5 (What's the path?), It's the path Bill and Bob followed helping other alcoholics stay sober. 1935, 1939, 1952. AA had to scale up so the traditions came along to make us fit in a diverse world. In the 1960's, the concepts came along. "Should his own image in the mirror be too awful to contemplate (and it usually is), he might first take a look at the results normal people are getting from self-sufficiency.

→ Everywhere he sees people filled with anger and fear, society breaking up into warring fragments. Each fragment says to the others, "We are right and you are wrong." Every such pressure group, if it is strong enough, self-righteously imposes its will upon the rest. And everywhere the same thing is being done on an ~~an~~ individual basis. The sum of all this mighty effort is less peace and less brotherhood than before. The philosophy of self-sufficiency is not paying off. Plainly enough, it is a bone-crushing juggernaut whose final achievement is ruin." There are many paths to sobriety and service. We see that this program works. Along the line in the concepts, replace your name for the word conference. In concept 12 "And, at times, the Conference (my name) will need to take certain protective actions, especially in the area of Tradition violations. This action, however, never need be punitively or aggressively controversial at the public level." I had to model my life after AA. Don't punish people. Cease conflict, observe minority opinion, do not hurt each other, instead build each other up. Live according to the 36 principles. Help others not be left out.

Discussion ended at 11:55 PM